STIVEN CATALYST

FIRST SERIES · OCTOBER 2026

# MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.




STRATEGY

## MEETINGS THAT PRODUCE DECISIONS

How much time meetings take, why so many end without a decision, which formats change that, and a card that turns a meeting into a decision.

**71%** of 182 senior managers said meetings are unproductive and inefficient.

PERLOW ET AL., 2017

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NO. 13 · STRATEGY

# In this issue

Meetings are where most managers spend their week, and where many decisions should be made and are not. Two things follow: what that time costs, and the meeting whose only job is to decide.

Executives spend nearly 23 hours a week in meetings, and most of 182 senior managers called them unproductive. Bain found one weekly meeting of a top team that, with its preparation, took 300,000 hours a year. In Microsoft's data, most meetings have no invite. Patrick Lencioni separates the meeting into four kinds, and two studies show that the format itself can save time without losing decisions.

*Stiven Janaqi* EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST


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## HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

**Figure**
Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

**Our reading**
Where the editors interpret rather than the research, it says so.

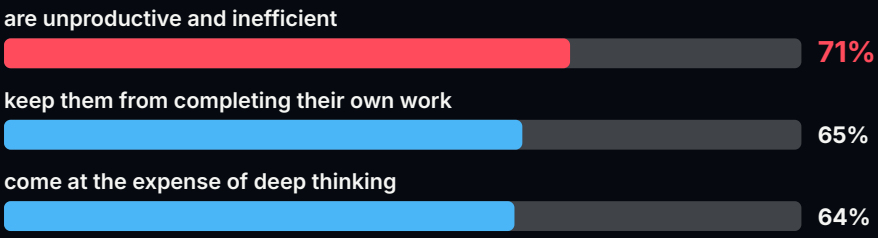
**Practice**
The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

# Twenty-three hours a week

Executives spend nearly 23 hours a week in meetings on average, up from less than 10 hours in the 1960s. Leslie Perlow, Constance Noonan Hadley and Eunice Eun asked 182 senior managers what this costs.

SENIOR MANAGERS WHO SAY MEETINGS…




*Share of 182 senior managers in the survey by Perlow, Hadley and Eun (2017). Their own view of their meetings.*

Bain studied how 17 large companies spend their time. In one large company, a single weekly meeting of the top team, together with the meetings that prepared it, took about 300,000 hours a year.

**15%**
of an organisation's collective time goes into meetings, more every year since 2008

**300,000**
hours a year for one weekly meeting of the top team

**Over half**
of their meetings were rated ineffective by senior executives

OUR READING

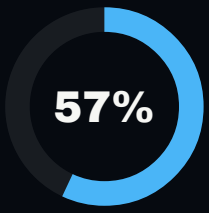
A meeting costs more than the hour in the calendar: multiply that hour by the people in the room, then add the meetings that prepare it.

Sources: Leslie A. Perlow, Constance Noonan Hadley & Eunice Eun, Harvard Business Review, 2017; Michael Mankins, Chris Brahm & Gregory Caimi, Harvard Business Review, 2014

THE NUMBERS

# The meeting without an invite

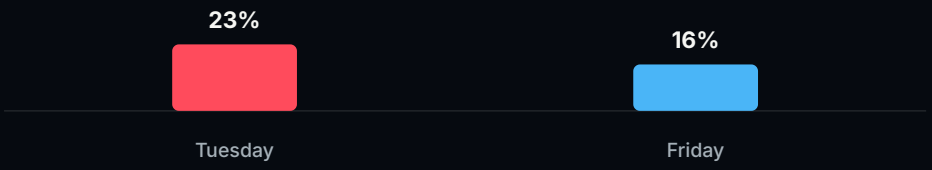
Microsoft analysed anonymised data from its office software up to 15 February 2025, with a survey of 31,000 workers. Customers in the EU are not included, so the figures describe workplaces outside it.




of meetings were ad hoc calls, without a calendar invite.

*Microsoft's anonymised office-software data up to 15 February 2025; EU customers not included.*

SHARE OF THE WEEK'S MEETINGS




*Share of a week's meetings by day, same data.*

**+16%**
meetings that start after 8 p.m., in one year

**275**
interruptions a day by meetings, emails or chats, for the most-pinged fifth

OUR READING

A meeting without an invite has no agenda, no list of who should be there and no note afterwards. It can be useful; it cannot be checked.

Source: Microsoft, Work Trend Index, 2025

THE MODEL

# Four meetings, not one

In Death by Meeting (2004), Patrick Lencioni proposes four kinds of meetings, each with one purpose and its own length.

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 01 | **Daily check-in** | About five minutes, standing: who does what today. No problem-solving. |
| 02 | **Weekly tactical** | 45 to 90 minutes: a quick round, progress against the numbers, then an agenda built from what came up. |
| 03 | **Monthly strategic** | A few big issues, about two hours each, for debate and decision. |
| 04 | **Quarterly review** | One or two days away from daily work: strategy, the team and the direction. |

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, A TEAM'S CALENDAR

| | |
|---|---|
| **Every day** | Check-in at 8:55, five minutes |
| **Tuesday** | Tactical, one hour |
| **First Thursday** | Strategic, one issue, two hours |

Three slots instead of one long Monday meeting: the decision that needs debate gets its own two hours, and the check-in solves nothing. (The calendar is invented.)

OUR READING

Often the trouble is a single meeting doing four jobs. Count the jobs before you count the meetings.

Source: Patrick Lencioni, 2004 (via Summaries of the book)

The four kinds are Lencioni's; the lengths follow summaries of the book.

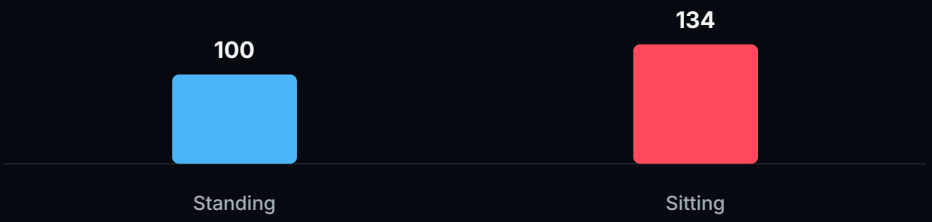
More in the essay — Ten minutes before the shift: what the team needs to know before the work starts

WHAT CHANGES THE MEETING

# Standing up, and days without

Two studies change the shape of the meeting and leave its agenda alone: one changed the chairs, the other the calendar.

LENGTH OF THE MEETINGS, STANDING = 100




*Index, standing meetings = 100. One 1999 experiment with students: 56 groups standing, 55 sitting, short meetings on a well-defined problem.*

The groups that sat took 34% longer and did not make better decisions. In the 1999 experiment, 56 groups of five met standing and 55 sitting. They were students solving a well-defined problem in short meetings, and the authors asked for research on longer, less structured ones.

A 2022 study looked at 76 companies with more than 1,000 employees that had introduced between one and five meeting-free days a week. With one such day, employees reported more autonomy, communication, engagement and satisfaction, and less micromanagement and stress. These were their own ratings; there was no experiment.

OUR READING

Both studies change the default: fewer chairs, fewer free slots. Nobody had to promise to meet better, and a default is easier to keep than any such promise.

Sources: Allen C. Bluedorn, Daniel B. Turban & Mary Sue Love, Journal of Applied Psychology, 1999 (via Abstract); Benjamin Laker, Vijay Pereira, Pawan Budhwar & Ashish Malik, MIT Sloan Management Review, 2022

HOW IT IS MEASURED

# What one meeting costs

Bain's 300,000 hours counted the meeting and all the meetings that prepare it. The same sum, people times hours times weeks, works for any team.

1. **List the recurring meetings**
   Name, length, how often, who attends.
2. **Multiply**
   People × hours × meetings a year.
3. **Ask what it decided**
   The decisions of the last four sessions. If there were none, send the update in writing.
4. **Change one meeting**
   Shorter, fewer people or standing, and check again in a month.

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, A WEEKLY TEAM MEETING

| | |
|---|---|
| **People** | 8 |
| **Length** | 1.5 hours |
| **Meetings a year** | 46 |
| **Total** | 552 hours a year |

About a third of one person's working year, before any preparation. (Numbers made up.)

Source: Michael Mankins, Chris Brahm & Gregory Caimi, Harvard Business Review, 2014

The steps and the example are our own.

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

# The decision card

One card for a meeting that has to decide. Send it before the meeting; fill in the last lines before anyone leaves the room.

**01 The question** one sentence that ends with a question mark

**02 Who decides** one name, as in No. 8

**03 Who is heard first** and who only needs the result

**04 Options on the table**

**05 The decision** in one sentence, with the reason

**06 Who does what, by when**

The editors propose this practice. The decision roles follow No. 8 of the Management Review.

SOURCES AND METHOD

# Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

**Stop the Meeting Madness**
Leslie A. Perlow, Constance Noonan Hadley & Eunice Eun, Harvard Business Review, 2017
https://hbr.org/2017/07/stop-the-meeting-madness

**Your Scarcest Resource**
Michael Mankins, Chris Brahm & Gregory Caimi, Harvard Business Review, 2014
https://hbr.org/2014/05/your-scarcest-resource

**Breaking down the infinite workday**
Microsoft, Work Trend Index, 2025
https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/worklab/work-trend-index/breaking-down-infinite-workday

**Death by Meeting**
Patrick Lencioni, 2004 · via Summaries of the book

**The effects of stand-up and sit-down meeting formats on meeting outcomes**
Allen C. Bluedorn, Daniel B. Turban & Mary Sue Love, Journal of Applied Psychology, 1999 · via Abstract
https://doi.org/10.1037/0021-9010.84.2.277

**The Surprising Impact of Meeting-Free Days**
Benjamin Laker, Vijay Pereira, Pawan Budhwar & Ashish Malik, MIT Sloan Management Review, 2022
https://sloanreview.mit.edu/article/the-surprising-impact-of-meeting-free-days/

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what exactly it measures. Where the publisher's page could not be opened, the figure was checked against independent summaries and is marked “via”. The editors' interpretation is marked “Our reading”. Figures that could not be confirmed are not in the issue.



# MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.

Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

## ALL ISSUES

stivencatalyst.com/magazine/management-review.html

Management Review · No. 13 · October 2026 · Stiven Catalyst